

Tai Motion

TAI CHI · GUIDE SERIES

Stress-Relief Breathing

Simple, seated breathing practices to calm your body and quiet your mind — a few slow breaths, any time you need them.

Suitable for every level · No equipment needed

Welcome to your Breathing guide

When life feels stressful, your breath is the one calming tool you always carry with you. Slowing it down — even for a minute — sends a quiet signal to your body that it is safe to relax.

These gentle practices are done sitting comfortably in a chair. There is nothing to force and nothing to get “right.” You simply breathe a little more slowly and a little more kindly, and let your body do the rest.

Use them whenever you like — first thing in the morning, before a meal, in a waiting room, or any moment you feel your shoulders creeping up toward your ears.

A quick note before you begin. Breathe gently and never strain. If you ever feel light-headed or dizzy, simply let your breathing return to normal and rest. If you have a heart or lung condition, or any concern, check with your doctor before practising regularly.

How to use this guide

Get comfortable. Sit tall in a sturdy chair, both feet flat on the floor, hands resting easily in your lap.

Breathe softly. Where you can, breathe in through your nose. Keep every breath gentle — smooth and easy always beats big and forced.

Little and often. Even one minute helps. On the pages that follow, each practice has a photo and a simple breathing pattern to follow.

Belly Breathing

Good for switching on your body's natural calm.



1. Sit tall and rest one hand gently on your belly.
2. Breathe in slowly through your nose and feel your belly rise under your hand.
3. Breathe out slowly through your nose or mouth, feeling your belly softly fall.

Try: 6-8 slow breaths.

Keep your chest quiet — let all the movement happen in your belly.

The Calming Breath (4-6)

Good for easing tension quickly, anywhere.



1. Breathe in gently through your nose for a slow count of four.
2. Breathe out through your mouth for a longer, smooth count of six.
3. Keep the out-breath unhurried — no need to empty completely.

Try: In 4, out 6 · about 6 breaths.

A longer out-breath than in-breath is your body's built-in “calm” signal.

Pursed-Lip Breathing

Good for steadier, fuller, more comfortable breaths.



1. Breathe in gently through your nose with your mouth closed.
2. Purse your lips softly, as if to blow out a candle without putting it out.
3. Breathe out slowly and evenly through your pursed lips — about twice as long as the in-breath.

Try: 6-8 breaths.

Especially soothing if you ever feel a little short of breath.

Hand-on-Heart Breath

Good for comfort, warmth and self-kindness.



1. Rest one hand over the center of your chest and feel its gentle warmth.
2. Breathe in slowly, letting your chest rise softly under your hand.
3. Breathe out slowly, offering yourself one kind or grateful thought.

Try: 5-6 slow breaths.

A simple way to feel steadier when the day feels heavy.

The Letting-Go Sigh

Good for releasing built-up tension fast.



1. Take a big breath in, letting your shoulders float up toward your ears.
2. At the top, sip in a tiny bit more air.
3. Let it all go with a long, audible sigh as your shoulders drop and soften.

Try: 3-4 sighs.

One of the quickest ways to reset when you feel wound up.

Steady Square Breath

Good for focus and a calm, even rhythm.



1. Breathe in through your nose for a gentle count of four.
2. Hold softly for four.
3. Breathe out for four, then rest for four before the next breath.

Try: 4·4·4·4 — about 4 rounds.

If holding feels at all uneasy, shorten the counts — comfort always comes first.

Your 5-minute calm-down

Feeling wound up? Move gently through these — no rush.

1. The Letting-Go Sigh — 3 sighs to release
2. Belly Breathing — 6 slow breaths to settle
3. The Calming Breath (4-6) — 6 breaths to soften
4. Hand-on-Heart Breath — 5 breaths to finish, with one kind thought

Notice the shift. When you're done, sit quietly for a moment. See if your shoulders sit a little lower and your mind feels a little quieter than when you began.

Making it a gentle habit

Tie it to a daily moment

Pair a minute of breathing with something you already do — your morning tea, sitting down to a meal, or getting into bed. Small and regular is what makes it stick.

Use it in the moment

These practices work best exactly when you need them — a stressful phone call, a busy shop, a restless night. A few slow breaths can change how a moment feels.

When to check with your doctor. Please speak with a healthcare professional if you often feel breathless, dizzy, or anxious, or if slow breathing ever feels uncomfortable. These practices are meant to feel calming — your comfort is always the guide.

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